Baked Mac and Cheese (CUT Steakhouse)

Main dishes | Oven

Before you start

Serves 8-10. Prep about 20 minutes; total about 1 hour 10 minutes. Use a buttered 3-4-quart baking dish; bake at 375°F about 30 minutes and rest 10 minutes.

Ingredients

Keep these ingredients separate; follow the order in the directions.

- [ ] 1 pound dried cavatappi pasta, or other bite-sized pasta tubes
- [ ] 6 tablespoons (3/4 stick) unsalted butter, plus extra for greasing
- [ ] 6 tablespoons all-purpose flour

- [ ] 1 bay leaf
- [ ] 4 cups milk
- [ ] 1 1/2 cups crème fraîche
- [ ] 1 1/2 teaspoons sea salt, plus extra as needed
- [ ] 3 3/4 cups freshly shredded mozzarella cheese
- [ ] 1 3/4 cups freshly shredded aged cheddar cheese
- [ ] Freshly ground white pepper
- [ ] 3/4 cup fresh brioche bread crumbs

1. Prepare and cook

1. Bring a large pot of salted water to a boil. Meanwhile, fill a large bowl with ice cubes and water and place it near the sink. Add the pasta to the boiling water and cook until al dente (tender but still chewy), according to package instructions. Drain the pasta and immediately add it to the ice water, stirring until cooled, 1 to 2 minutes. Drain well and set aside.

2. Preheat an oven to 375 degrees. Butter a 3- to 4-quart square baking dish. Set aside.

3. Meanwhile, in a large saucepan, melt the butter over medium heat. Stirring continuously with a wire whisk, sprinkle in the flour and cook, stirring, for 1 minute. Add the bay leaf and, whisking continuously, slowly pour in the milk until smooth. Simmer, whisking occasionally, until the mixture has thickened, about 14 to 16 minutes. Remove and discard the bay leaf. Whisk in the crème fraîche and the salt; bring the mixture to a simmer.

4. Remove the pan from the heat and stir in 11/4 cups each of the mozzarella and cheddar until melted. Season to taste with some salt and white pepper.

5. In a large mixing bowl, combine the pasta and cheese sauce. Stir in 2 cups more of the mozzarella. Transfer the mixture to the prepared baking dish, spreading it evenly. Evenly sprinkle the remaining mozzarella and cheddar over the top, and then sprinkle with the bread crumbs.

6. Bake in the preheated oven until the mixture is bubbly and the bread crumbs are golden brown (about 30 minutes). Remove from the oven and leave to settle at room temperature for 10 minutes before scooping and serving.

Notes

From and tested by Wolfgang Puck, as credited in the saved file. Keep cheese portions separate: 1 1/4 cups each mozzarella and cheddar for sauce; 2 cups mozzarella mixed with pasta; remaining 1/2 cup each cheese for topping.